



WITH A LOAN WAIVER OF RS 17 LAKH AND THEIR DECISION TO VENTURE INTO VEGETABLE AND ONION FARMING FIVE YEARS AGO, THE UGALE BROTHERS, FROM A TRIBAL FAMILY OF NASIK, HAVE TOUCHED A TURNOVER OF RS 27 LAKH PER ANNUM

and paper boards are being increasingly favoured in place of plastic. "Today each of us makes about Rs 2,000 a month," says Malini Sudhakaran, Karunya's secretary. They also run a micro credit system and help each other in emergencies with small grants and loans. There are an incredible 37 lakh poor women who are members of Kudumbasree, making it Asia's largest women's self-help and micro credit movement. Launched in 1999, Kudumbasree has become the largest poverty eradication project ever undertaken in the state, with a collective savings of Rs 1,191 crore while Rs 3,087 crore has been disbursed as loans to members.

One major beneficiary has been Technoworld, a Kudumbasree-funded unit which was set up in Thiruvananthapuram 10 years ago by a group of 10 housewives with basic computer literacy. They invested Rs 1,500 each and also got a state subsidy of Rs 1.50 lakh. Started with five computers today they have about 25, employ 60 women and made an annual profit of Rs 10 lakh last year through data entry jobs. "We also have purchased a new office building and land at a cost of Rs 27 lakh of which Rs 17 lakh are our internal resources and the rest a subsidy. Our personal lives too have been radically transformed in the last decade," says Shyla Beevi, the unit's secretary.

In a state which is highly polarised on political lines, Kudumbasree has won rare universal support. Says Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan: "Kudumbasree is a model for India in women's empowerment and poverty eradication." Opposition leader Oommen Chandy too has only praise for the programme: "One of the greatest silent revolutions the state has witnessed in recent times." Kudumbasree's Executive Director Sarada Muralidharan says the key to its success is its ability to unify women beyond divides such as caste, creed or politics. Muralidharan is just back from Brazil where at an international meet on women's empowerment she made a presentation on Kudumbasree which is winning global attention. Kudumbasree was one of the innovative Indian social experiments presented at last year's 9th International Conference on India at the Stanford University. The Canada-based



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